Infantry' connection helped us build a rapport with them early on. Their CO was Lt Col SHS Kottegoda, one of the rare Tamil COs in a predominantly Sinhala Army, and their 2iC was Maj Shane Balthazar, a Sri Lankan burgher of Dutch origin. Since all operations were now the responsibility of the IPKF, we had to carry out the ROP, notwithstanding the fact that there were SLA posts all along the road.

The post at the 4th Mile was in a dilapidated house that used to belong to a Tamil merchant who had since fled or been killed. It was a sprawling, two-storeyed wooden structure on the slope of a hill. There was a small room to the rear on the second floor which served as the officers' accommodation with the luxury of an attached toilet. On top of the hill was a civil water point, where a picquet would stand guard by day to prevent any firing on the post from this dominating height. To prevent being surprised at night, some anti-personnel mines and booby traps had been placed further up the hill by the previous unit. As part of the handing/taking over, Ramesh had been shown the location of the mines and IEDs. When I joined a day or so later, I too wanted to see overall security arrangements, so we went up once again to the top of the hill, an NCO leading the way. Being new to the location, the NCO misjudged the distances and accidentally activated the tripwire of our own IED booby trap. There was a loud click as the striker hit the detonator and breathless silence as we stood glued to the spot waiting for the inevitable blast. The seconds ticked by, none of us wanting to be the first one to move for fear of causing the IED to explode. After what seemed an eternity, we cautiously took a few steps back to safer ground. Lady Luck was smiling at us that day. However, it showed that the defensive measures that had been put in place had deteriorated with time and become ineffective, so we retrieved all the old mines and IEDs and put fresh ones

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